

pivot or persevere, whether to change direction or stay the course.

Third, many entrepreneurs are afraid. Acknowledging failure can lead to dangerously low morale. Most entrepreneurs' biggest fear is not that their vision will prove to be wrong. More terrifying is the thought that the vision might be deemed wrong without having been given a real chance to prove itself. This fear drives much of the resistance to the minimum viable product, split testing, and other techniques to test hypotheses. Ironically, this fear drives up the risk because testing doesn't occur until the vision is fully represented. However, by that time it is often too late to pivot because funding is running out. To avoid this fate, entrepreneurs need to face their fears and be willing to fail, often in a public way. In fact, entrepreneurs who have a high profile, either because of personal fame or because they are operating as part of a famous brand, face an extreme version of this problem.

A new startup in Silicon Valley called Path was started by experienced entrepreneurs: Dave Morin, who previously had overseen Facebook's platform initiative; Dustin Mierau, product designer and cocreator of Macster; and Shawn Fanning of Napster fame. They decided to release a minimum viable product in 2010. Because of the high-profile nature of its founders, the MVP attracted significant press attention, especially from technology and startup blogs. Unfortunately, their product was not targeted at technology early adopters, and as a result, the early blogger reaction was quite negative. (Many entrepreneurs fail to launch because they are afraid of this kind of reaction, worrying that it will harm the morale of the entire company. The allure of positive press, especially in our "home" industry, is quite strong.)

Luckily, the Path team had the courage to ignore this fear and focus on what their customers said. As a result, they were able to get essential early feedback from actual customers. Path's goal is to create a more personal social network that maintains its quality over time. Many people have had the experience of being overconnected on existing social networks, sharing with past coworkers, high school friends, relatives, and colleagues. Such broad groups make it hard to share intimate moments. Path took an